

Persuasion

Outline

1) Dual-Process Approach to Persuasion
    - Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM)
2) The Elements of Persuasion
    - Yale Attitude Change Approach
3) Metacognition and Persuasion
4) Resistance to Persuasion

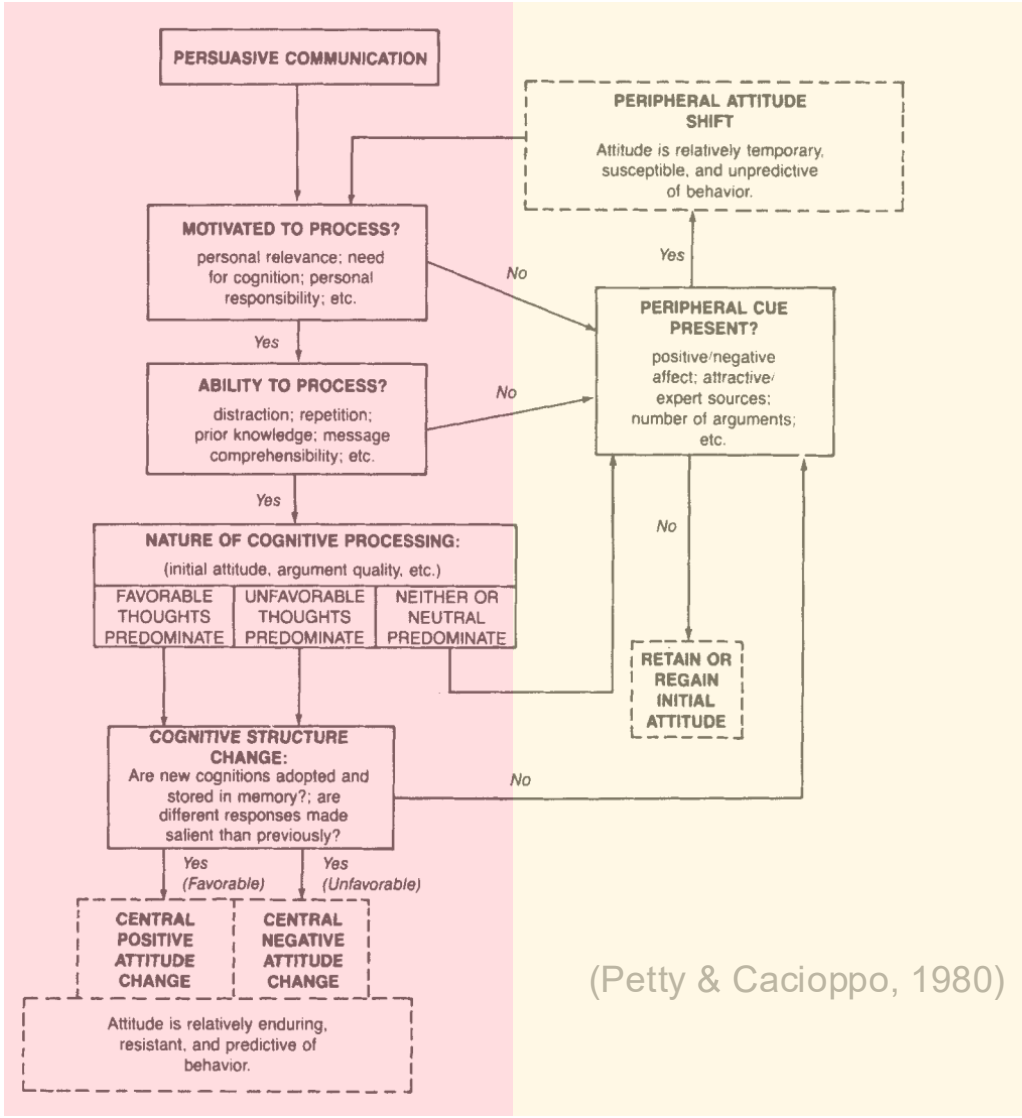
Persuasion

The process by which a message induces change in feelings, attitudes, or behaviors.

- How do we get people to feel, believe, and do what we want them to feel, believe, and do?

Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM)

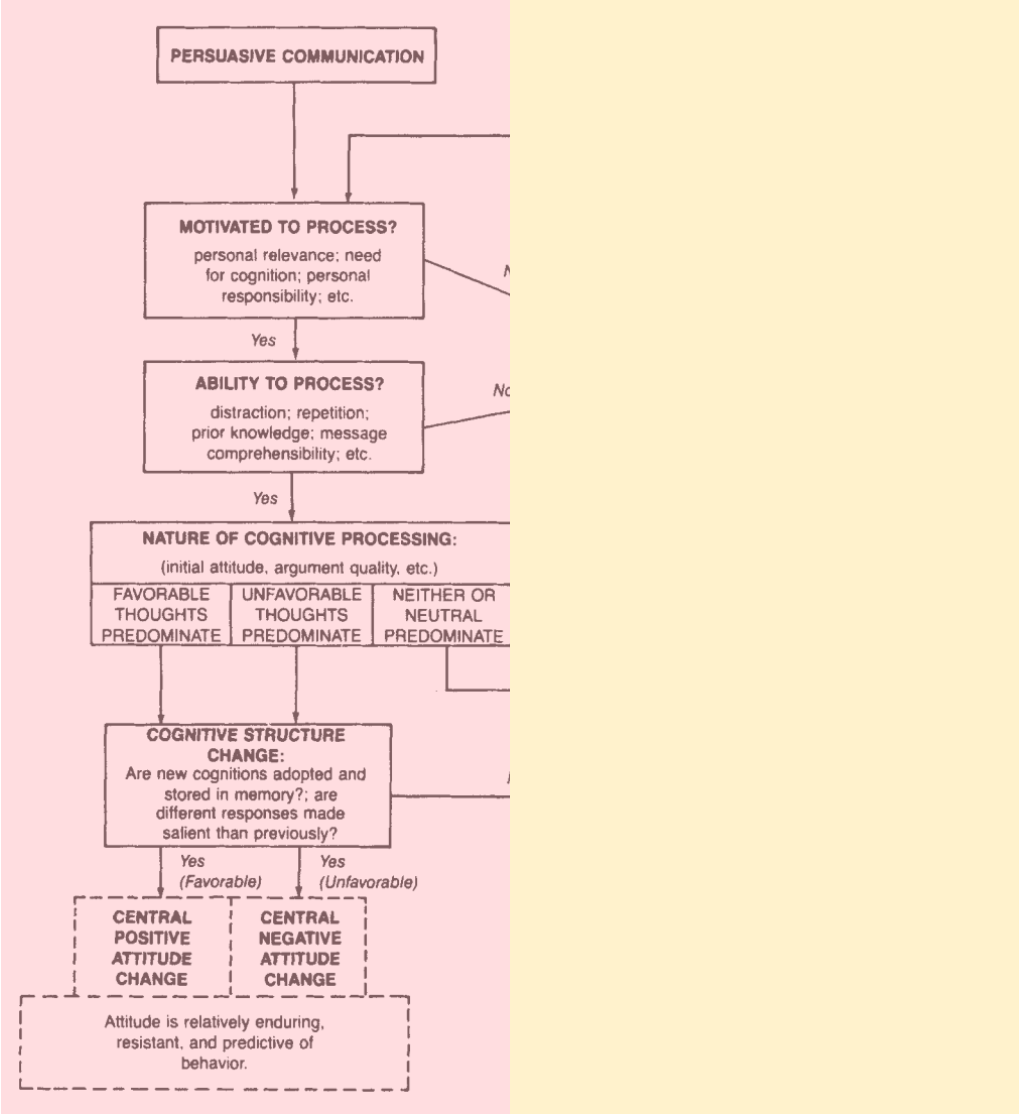
A model of persuasion maintaining that there are two different routes to persuasion: the central route and the peripheral route



(Petty & Cacioppo, 1980)

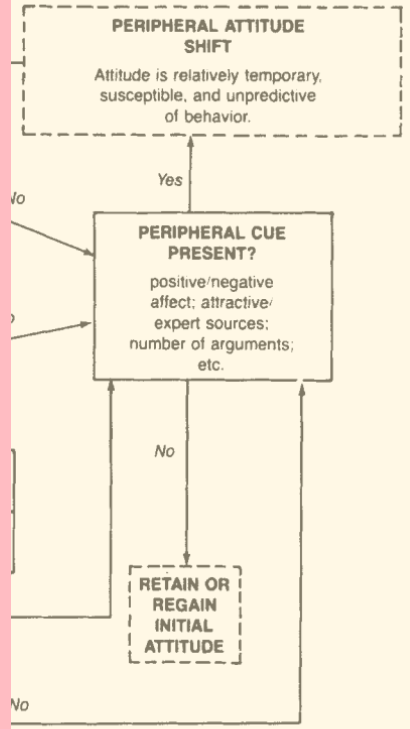
Elaboration Likelihood Model

- Persuasion via the Central Route:
  A route to persuasion wherein people think carefully and deliberately about the content of a persuasive message, attending to its logic and the strength of its arguments, as well as to related evidence and principles.



Elaboration Likelihood Model

- Persuasion via the Peripheral Route:
  A route to persuasion wherein people attend to relatively easy-to-process, superficial cues related to persuasive message, such as its length or the expertise or attractiveness of the of source of the message.



(Petty & Cacioppo, 1980)

Example - Central vs. Peripheral Route

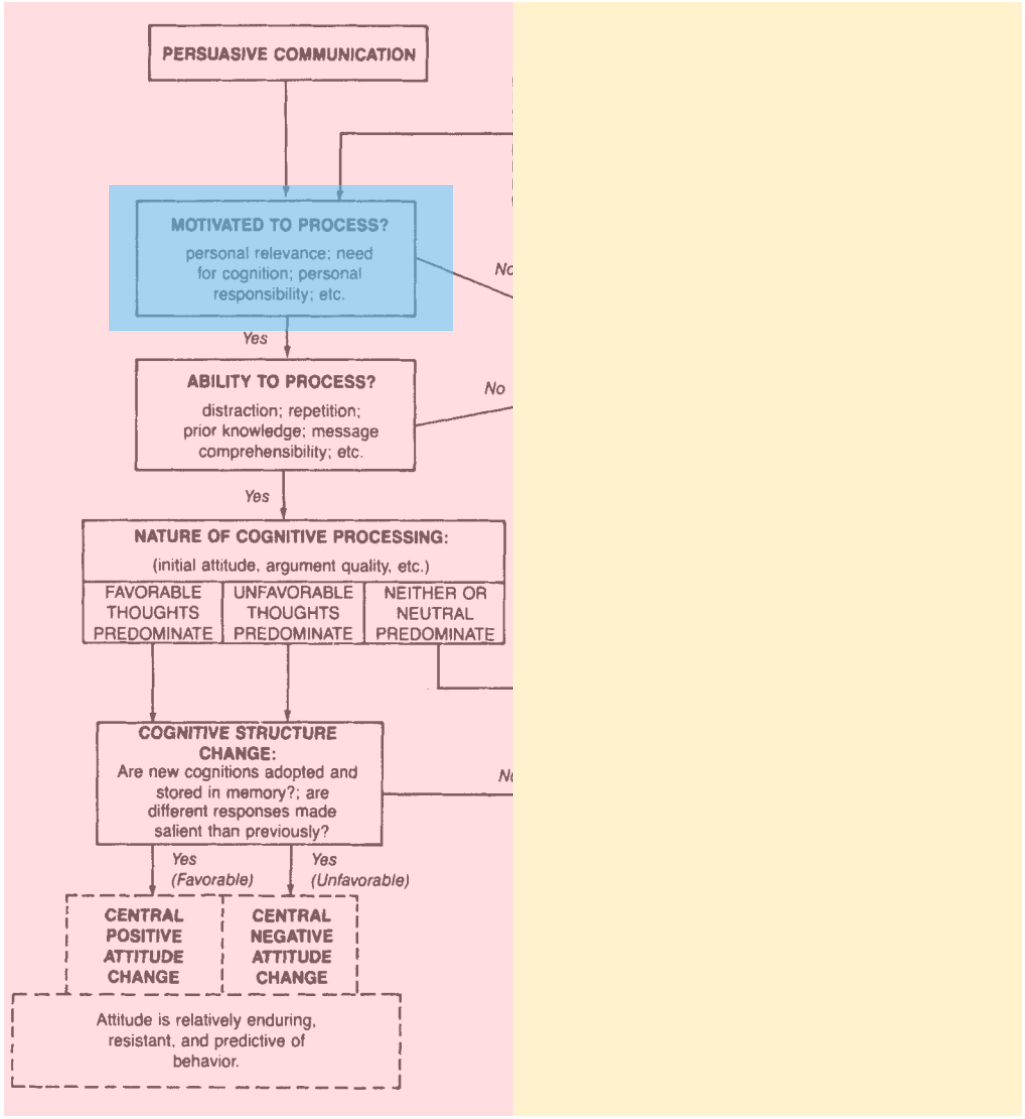
Central Route



Peripheral Route



Elaboration Likelihood Model

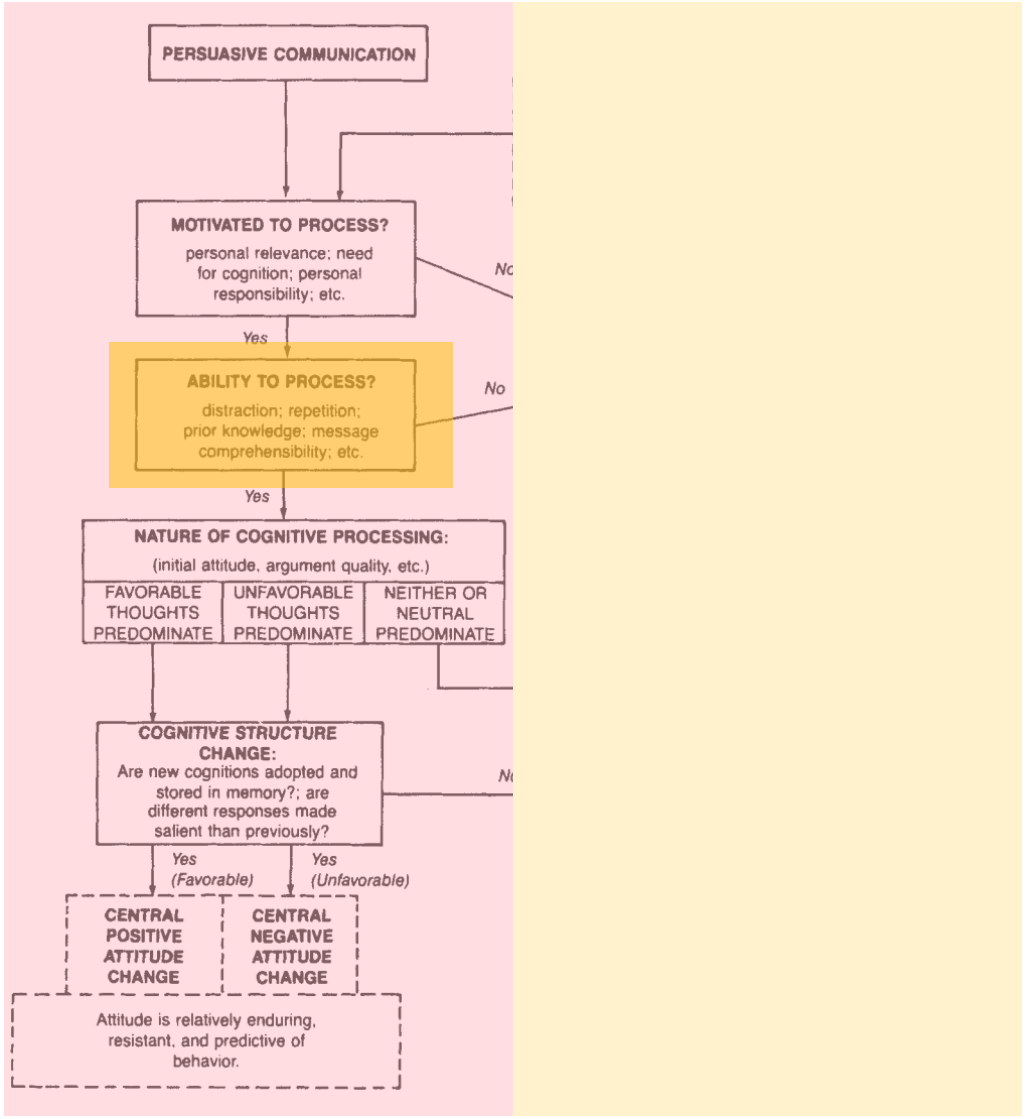


Motivation

- **Motivation** to process the arguments
  - Personal relevance: goals, interests, or well-being



Elaboration Likelihood Model

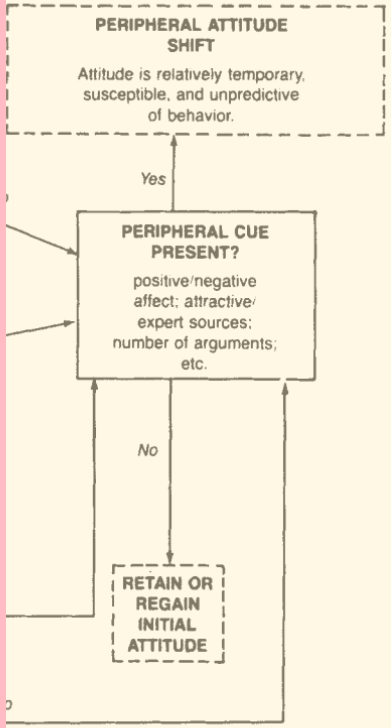


Ability

- **Ability** to process the arguments
  - Individuals:
    - Cognitive resources
    - Intelligence/knowledge
  - Stimuli:
    - Message clarity
    - Limited time



Elaboration Likelihood Model



Motivation x Ability

	Motivated: Yes	Motivated: No
Ability: Yes		
Ability: No		

Motivation x Ability

	Motivated: Yes	Motivated: No
Ability: Yes	Central	
Ability: No		

Argument quality is important to the Central Route

- Strong arguments – make you more favorable toward the object/issue
- Weak arguments – make you less favorable toward the object/issue

Attitudes changed via the Central Route are

Stronger Attitudes:

- Last longer
- More predictive of behavior
- More resistant to change

Motivation x Ability

	Motivated: Yes	**Motivated: No**
Ability: Yes	Central	Peripheral
Ability: No	Peripheral	Peripheral

Argument quality is is less important to the Peripheral Route

Strong arguments and weak arguments can have the same effect.

- Strong arguments are less impactful.
- Weak arguments are less damaging.

Attitudes changed via the Peripheral Route are

Weaker attitudes:

- last less longer; more temporary
- less predictive of behavior
- less resistant to other people trying to influence our attitudes

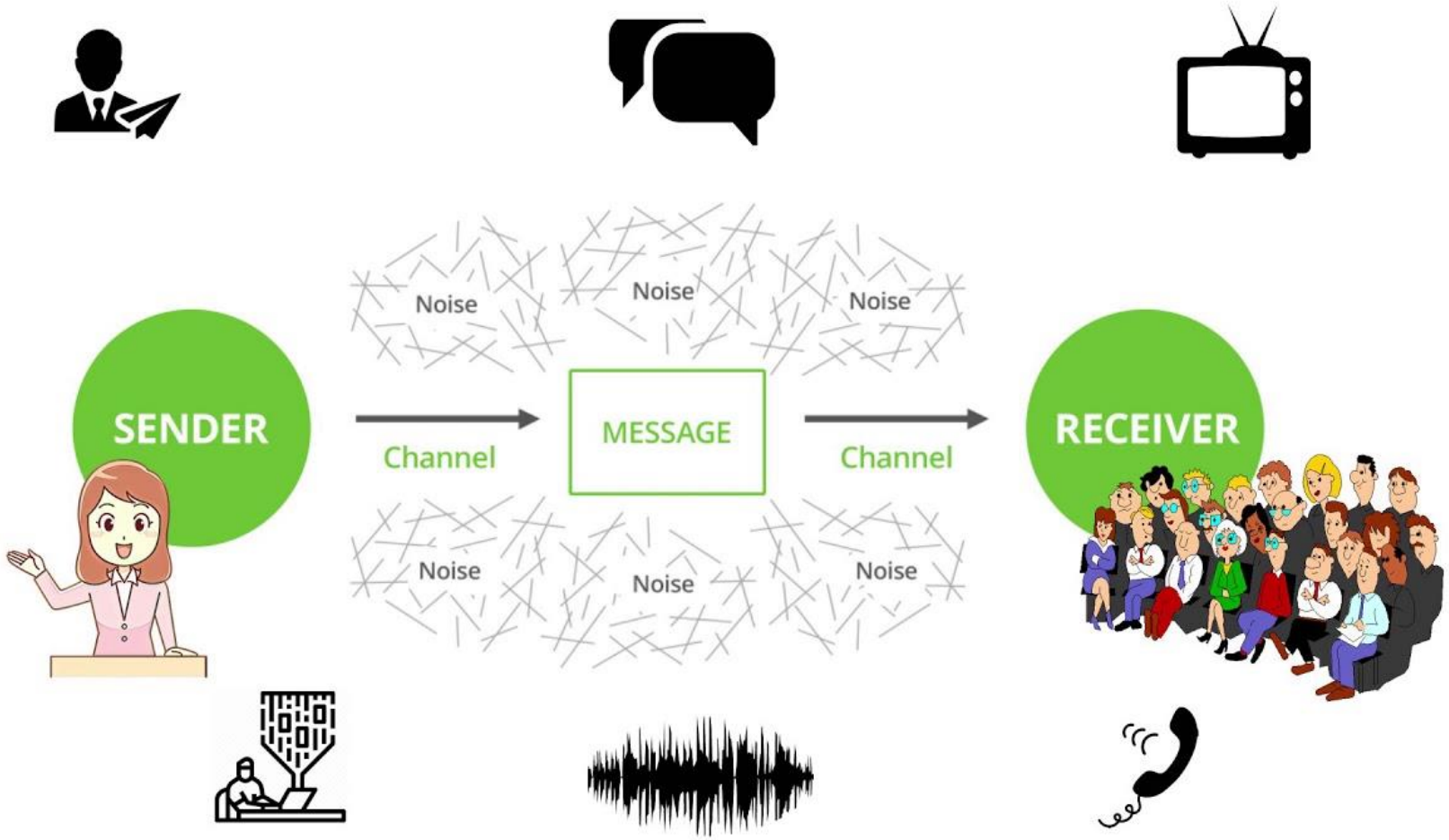
How to change attitude?

Motivation x Ability

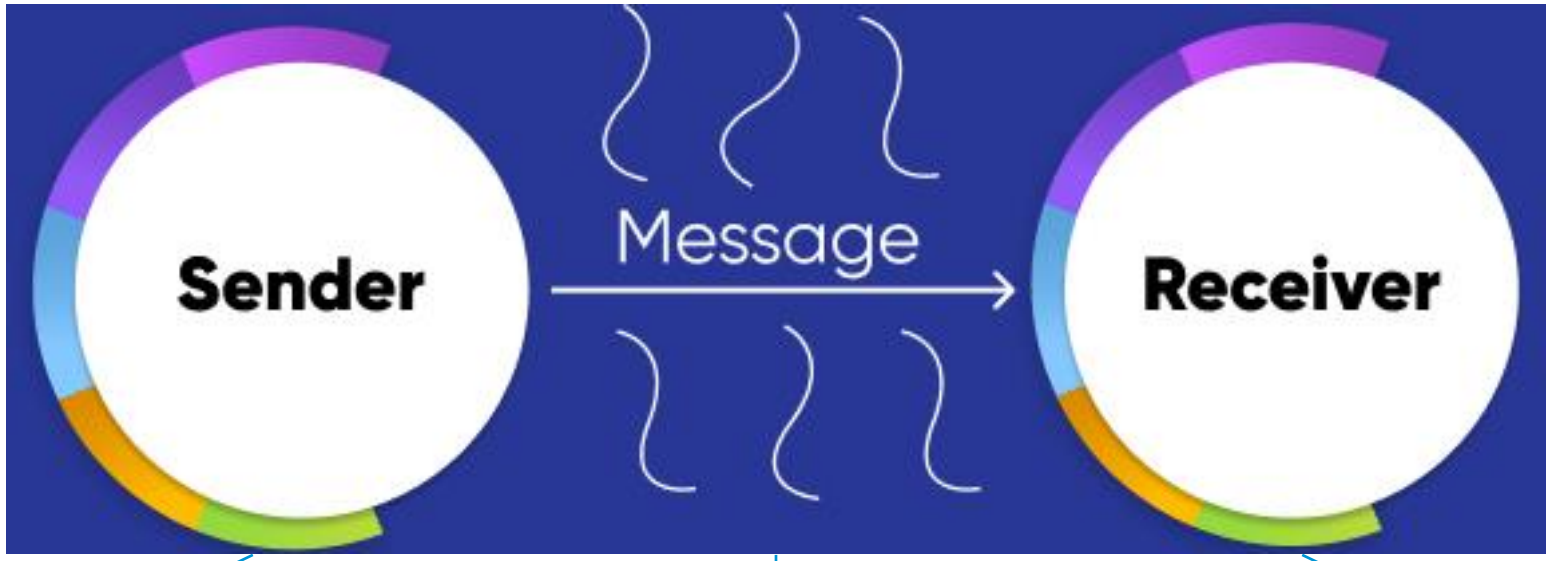
	Motivated: Yes	**Motivated: No**
Ability: Yes	Central	Peripheral
Ability: No	Peripheral	Peripheral

Yale Attitude Change Approach

Yale Attitude Change Approach



Yale Attitude Change Approach



Sender's Characteristics
(who said it?)

Message Characteristics
(what was said?)

Audience Characteristics
(to whom?)

Sender's Characteristics

- Credibility
  - Expertise
  - Trustworthiness/Self-Interest

Sender's Characteristics: Credibility

- People who are seen as knowledgeable and trustworthy are more persuasive.
- However, noncredible sources can change attitudes through the sleeper effect.
    - An effect that occurs when a persuasive message from an unreliable source initially exerts little influence but later causes attitudes to shift



Sender's Characteristics

- Credibility
  - Expertise
  - Trustworthiness/Self-Interest
- Attractiveness
  - Physical Appeal
  - Similarity

Sender's Characteristics: Attractiveness

- Attractiveness
  - Attractive spokespeople are more persuasive, even for topics completely unrelated to attractiveness.
  - Effects of attractiveness are through the peripheral route: attractive people are rated more favorably, and those favorable feelings become associated with the message.



Sender's Characteristics

- Credibility
  - Expertise
  - Trustworthiness/Self-Interest
- Attractiveness
  - Physical Appeal
  - Similarity
- Certainty/confidence

Sender's Characteristics: Certainty

- Certainty
  - Senders who express their views with certainty and confidence tend to be more persuasive.
  - If your goal is to persuade someone, be sure to express lots of confidence.

Message Characteristics

- Message quality
  - Conclusions are explicit in the message ---”Here is the take-away message”
  - Senders argue against their own self-interest.
- Vividness

Message Characteristics: Vividness

When information is vivid---colorful, interesting, and memorable--- it tends to be more effective.



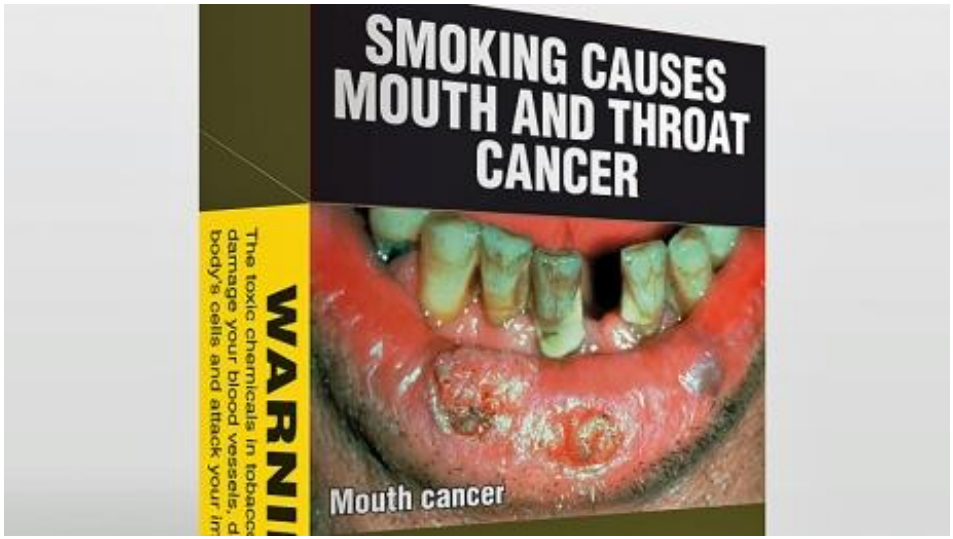
Identifiable victim effect

The tendency to be more moved by the vivid plight of a single individual than by a more abstract number of people.

Message Characteristics

- Message quality
  - Conclusions are explicit in the message ---"Here is the take-away message"
  - Sources argue against their own self-interest.
- Vividness
- Emotion
  - Positive feelings (peripheral processing)
  - Fear (fear messages are most effective when combined with instructions on how to avoid negative outcomes)

Message Characteristics: Fear





Message Characteristics: Fear

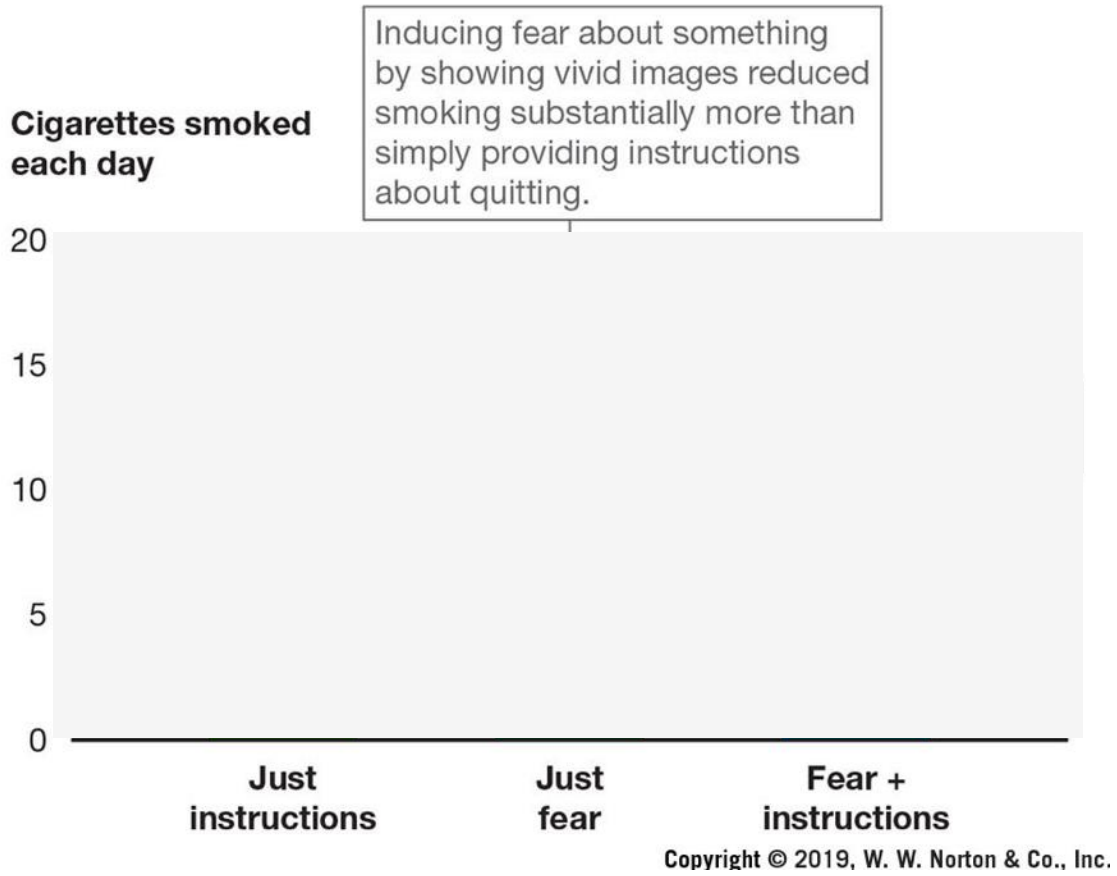


FIGURE 8.3
FEAR AND PERSUASIVE MESSAGES
Source: Adapted from Leventhal et al., 1967.

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Message Characteristics

- Message quality
  - Conclusions are explicit in the message ---"Here is the take-away message"
  - Sources argue against their own self-interest.
- Vividness
- Emotion
  - positive feelings (peripheral processing)
  - fear (fear messages are most effective when combined with instructions on how to avoid negative outcomes)
- Culture – fit norms and values of culture

Message Characteristics: Culture



Message Characteristics: Culture



Message Characteristics: Culture

- To tailor a message to fit the norms, values, and outlook of the cultural group of your audience.

American ads emphasized benefits to the individual.



"Make your way through the crowd."

Korean ads emphasized benefits to collectives.



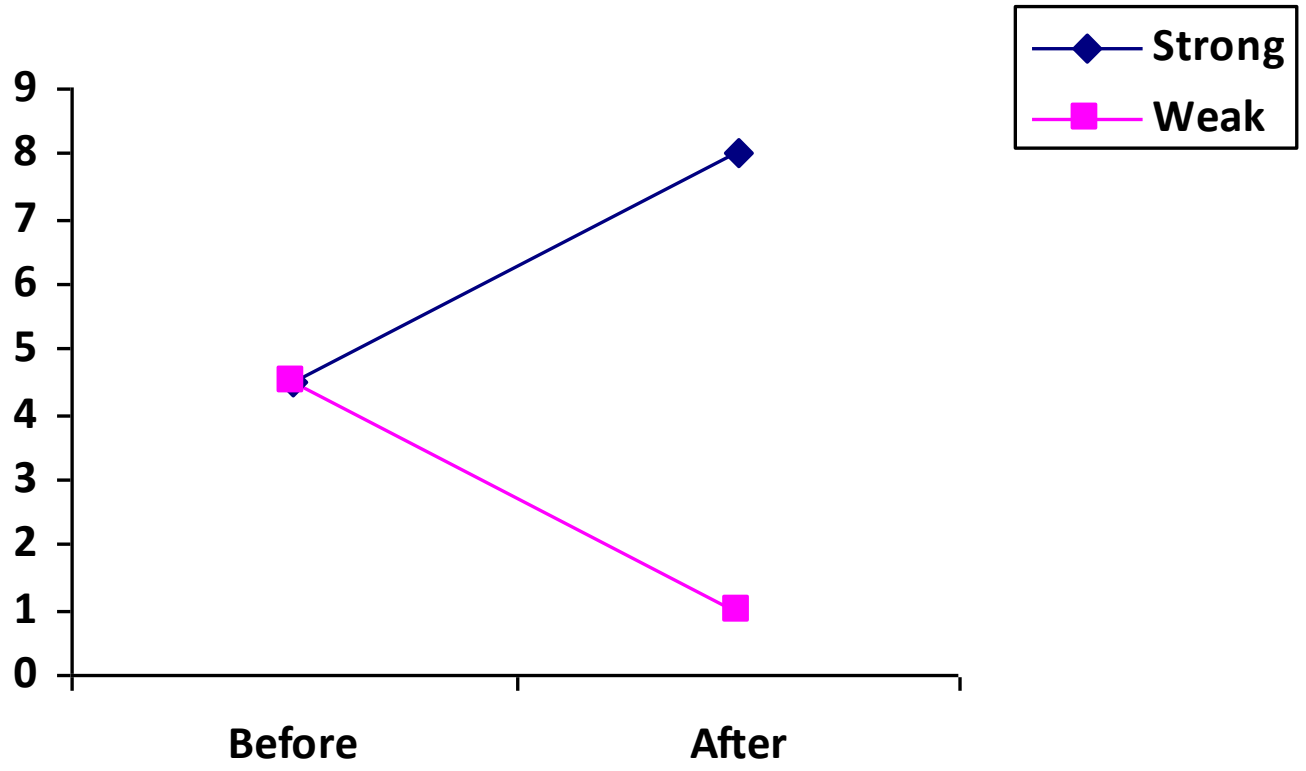
"We have a way of bringing people closer together."

Audience Characteristics

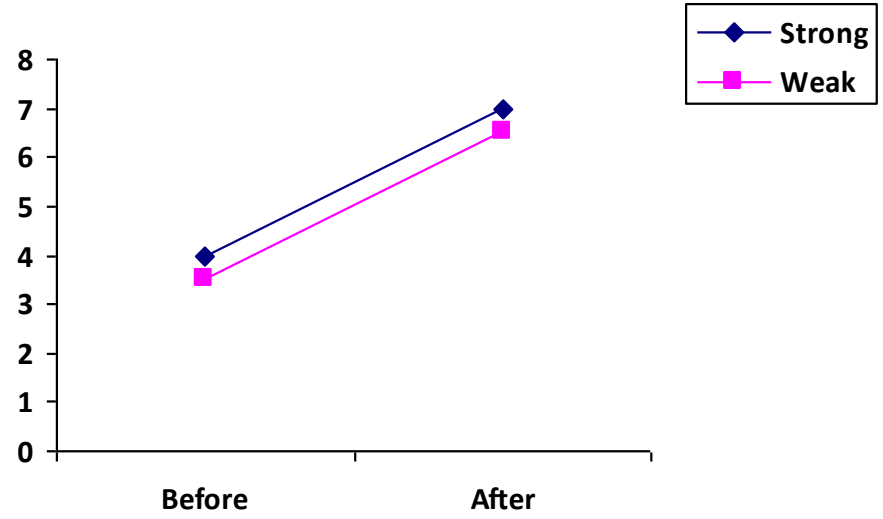
What are they thinking?

- The ability and motivation to counter-argue is the key to whether persuasion works (via the central route)
- Mood
- Age
- Need for Cognition/Need for Closure

Attitudes toward Voting - Argument Quality in General

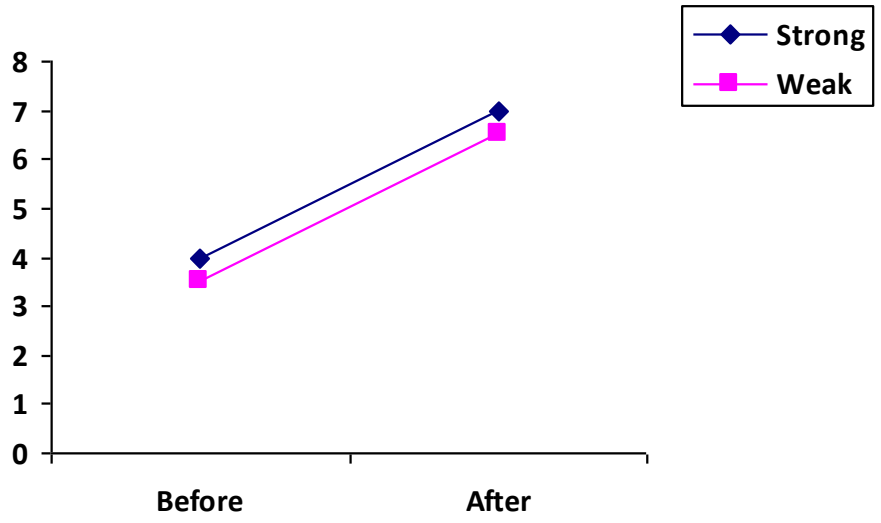


Attitudes toward Voting - Motivation



Low Motivation
(peripheral processing)

Attitudes toward Voting - Ability to Process



Low Ability to Process
(peripheral processing)

Audience Characteristics: Mood and Age

- Mood
  - Messages are more persuasive when they match the mood of the receiver.
    - Optimistic messages work best on happy people.
- Age
  - Younger people are more persuadable than older people.
    - Older people may have strong and long-held attitudes.
  - Children may be most vulnerable to persuasion attempts.

Audience Characteristics: Need for Cognition

A personality variable reflecting the extent to which people engage in and enjoy effortful cognitive activities.

Questions? - Need for Cognition

Score your response.

1 (extremely uncharacteristic of me) – 5 (extremely characteristic of me)

1. I usually end up deliberating about issues even when they do not affect me personally.
2. I only think as hard as I have to.

Audience Characteristics: Need for Cognition

- Need for cognition
  - Drive to think deeply about judgments
  - People high in need for cognition are more persuaded by central route messages than by peripheral route messages.

Summary

1. Communicator (who said it?)
- Credibility (Expert, Trustworthy/Self-Interest)
- Attractiveness (Physical Appeal, Similarity)
- Certainty/confidence

2. Message (what was said?)
- Message quality
- Emotion (Positive Feelings, Fear)
- Culture – fit norms and values of culture

3. Audience (to whom?)
- Motivation and Ability
- Age
- Mood
- Need for Cognition

Metacognition and Persuasion

Metacognition and Persuasion

Example: Your attitude toward reducing carbon emissions

- **Cognitions**: the origins of carbon emissions and their effects on the environment
- **Secondary cognitions**: assessments of how confident you are in your knowledge about carbon emissions, the ease with which facts about carbon emissions come to mind, or how clear the facts seem to you.

Metacognition and Persuasion

Metacognition: Secondary thoughts that are reflections on primary thoughts (cognitions).

- **Self-Validation Hypothesis**
- **Embodiment and Confidence**

The self-validation hypothesis

The idea that feeling confident about our thoughts validates those thoughts, making it more likely that we'll be swayed in their direction.

An experiment by Petty et al. (2002)

- Read a message arguing in favor of a new campus policy that would require all seniors to take a comprehensive exam before they graduate
- Reported their thoughts on the message
- Recalled a situation when they experienced confidence or doubt
- Reported their attitudes towards the message

The self-validation hypothesis

An experiment by Petty et al. (2002)

- Recalled confidence: Favorable thoughts reported more favorable attitudes while unfavorable thoughts reported more unfavorable attitudes.
- Recalled doubt: Favorable and unfavorable thoughts did not predict attitudes.

The favorability or unfavourability of one's thoughts influenced persuasion only when whey were associated with a feeling of confidence.



Embodiment and Confidence

Our confidence can also be conveyed through nonverbal cues.





- Message made up of strong arguments: Nodding the head is more persuasive
- Massage made up of weak arguments: Nodding the head is less persuasive

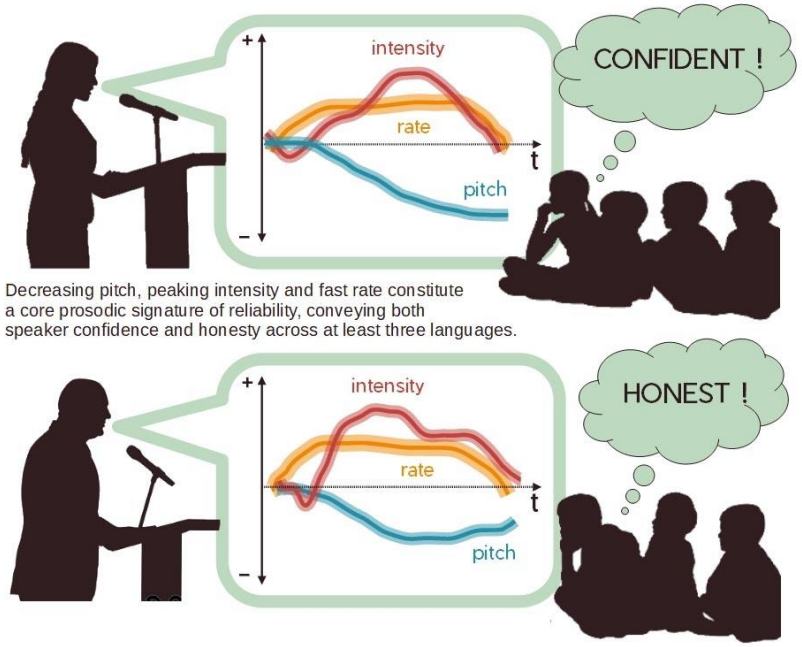
Embodiment and Confidence

Posture is upright or slouching





Tone of voice confident or uncertain



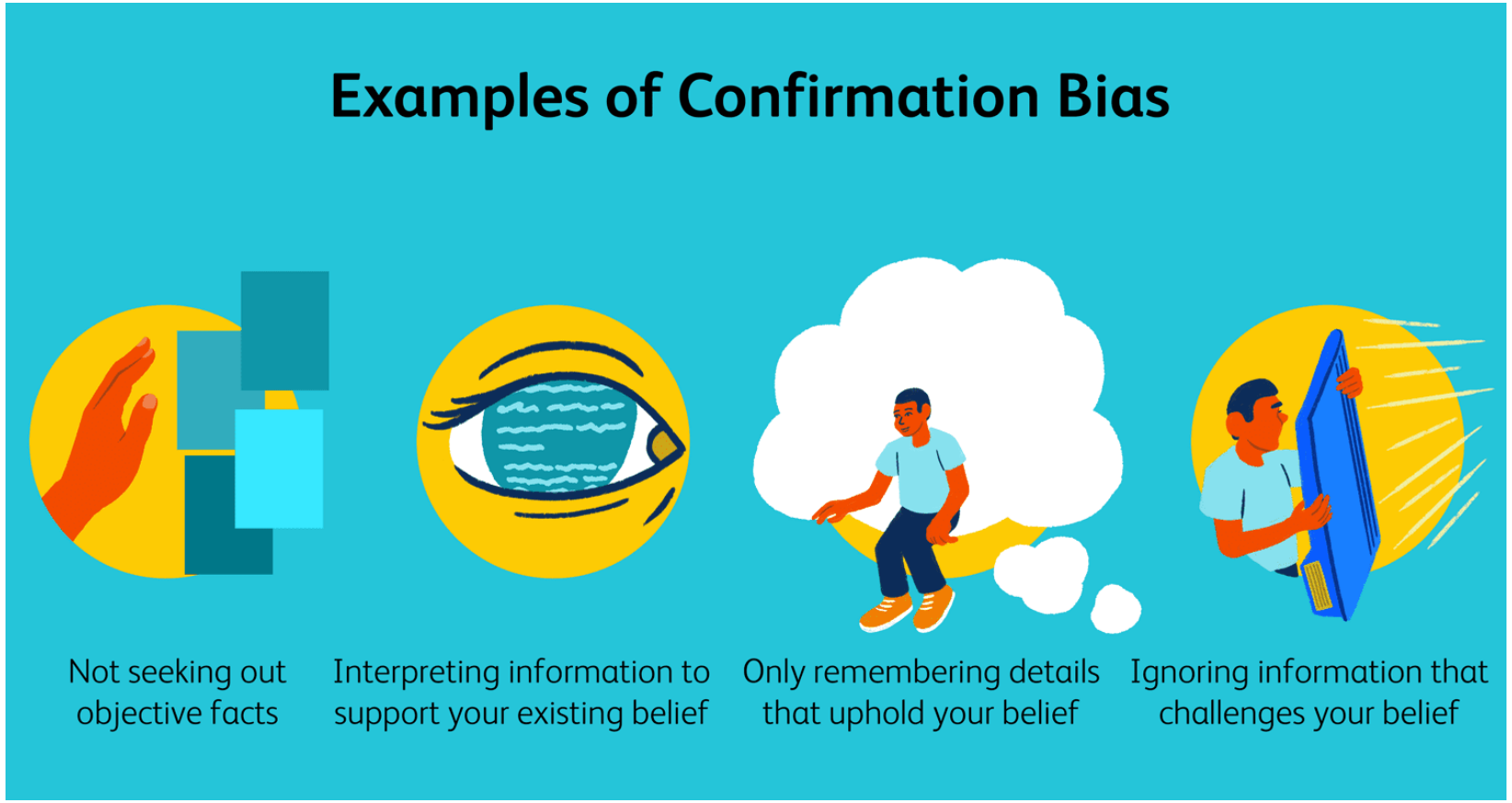
Resistance to Persuasion



Resistance to Persuasion

- Attentional bias and resistance
  - People are inclined to attend selectively to information that confirm their original attitudes.

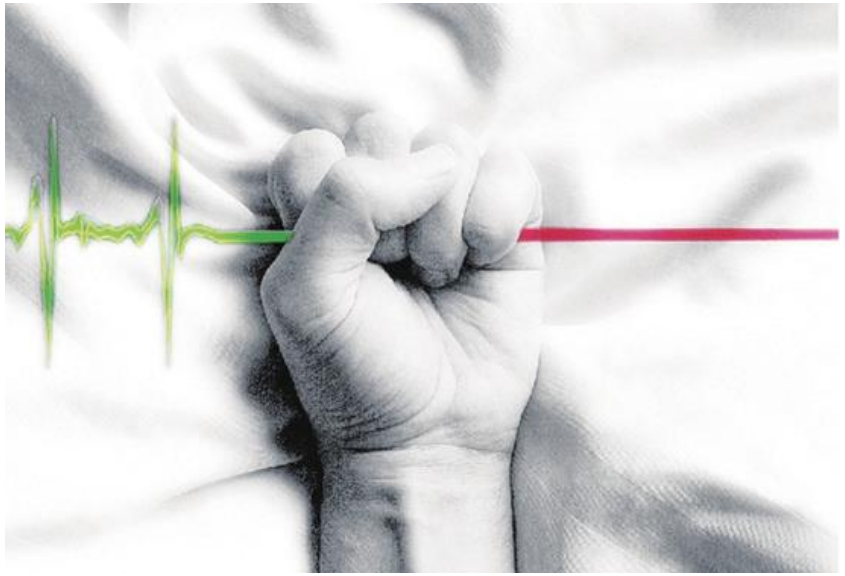
Resistance to Persuasion



Resistance to Persuasion

Experiment:

- Students who either supported or opposed the euthanasia listened to a message that advocated legalization.
- 14 arguments: 7 were strong and difficult to refute; 7 were silly and easy to refute
- Heard through headphones accompanied by a continual static buzz
- Press a button to eliminate the buzz for 5 seconds



Resistance to Persuasion

Results:

- The pro-legalization students pushed the button more often for strong arguments.
- The anti-legalization students pushed the button more often for weak arguments.

Resistance to Persuasion

- Attentional bias and resistance
  - People are inclined to attend selectively to information that confirm their original attitudes.
- Previous commitments and resistance
  - Many persuasive messages fail because they can't overcome the target audience's previous commitments.
- Knowledge and resistance **ELM**
  - People with a great deal of knowledge are more resistant to persuasion.

Attitude Inoculation

Small attacks on people's beliefs that engage their preexisting attitudes, prior commitments, and background knowledge, enabling them to counteract a subsequent larger attack and thus resist persuasion.



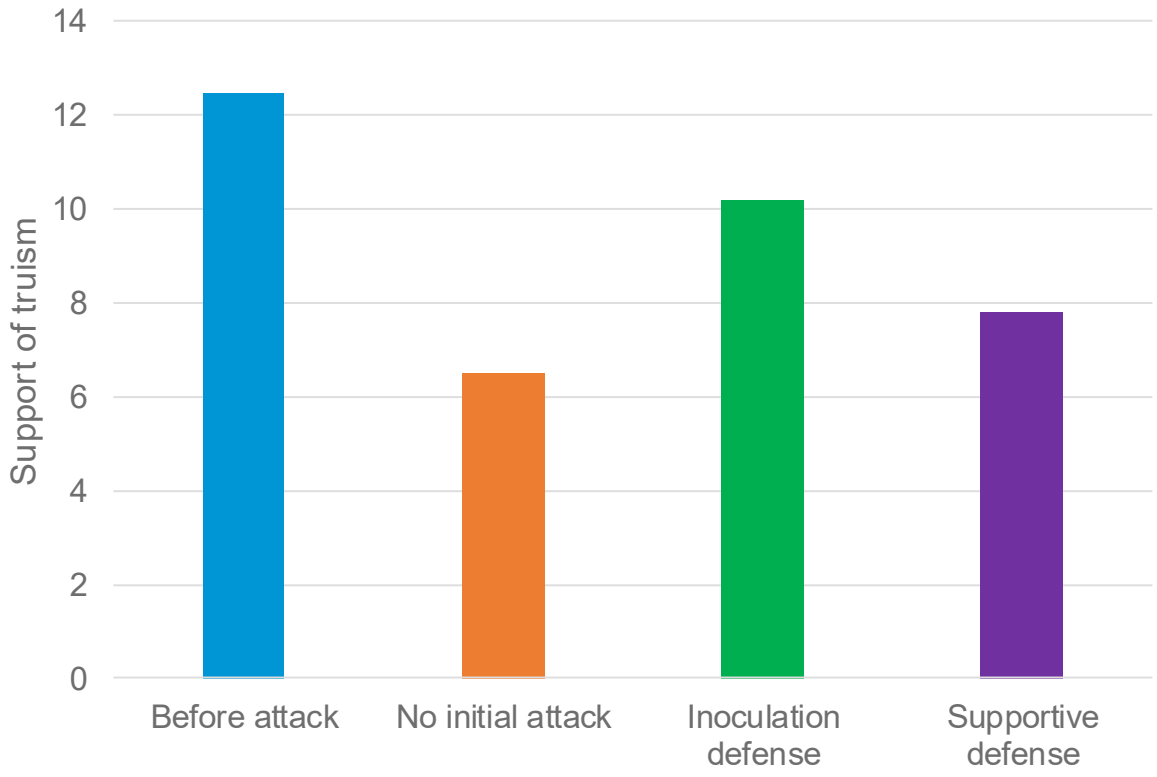
Attitude Inoculation

It is a good idea to brush your teeth after every meal if at all possible.



Too frequent brushing tends to damage the gums and expose the vulnerable parts of the teeth to decay.

- Offer arguments against it
- Offer arguments in support the truism





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